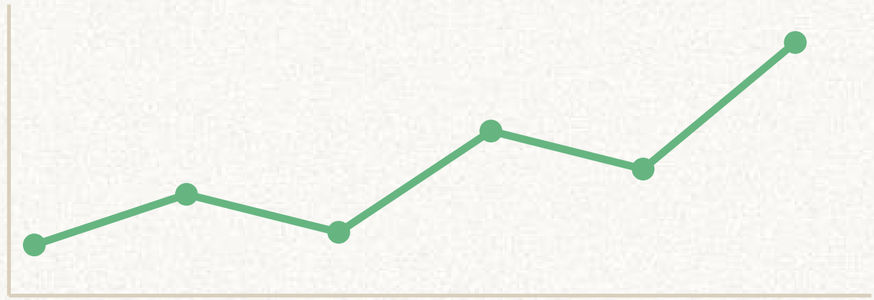
Lesson 1 · Writing

Understanding line graphs.

What line graphs are, how to read them, and what IELTS Writing Task 1 asks you to do with them.



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

01 Identify the key parts of a line graph.

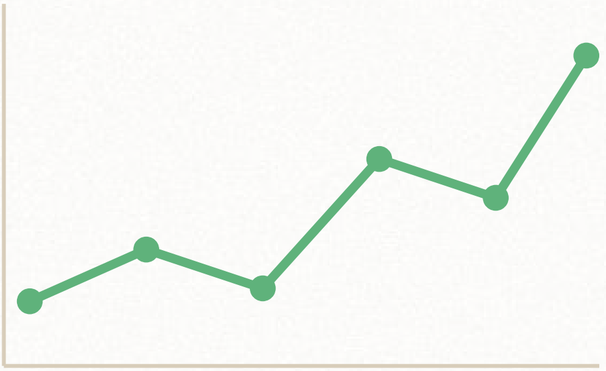
02 Recognise the difference between single and multiple line graphs.

03 Explain what IELTS Writing Task 1 asks you to do.

04 Identify the key features to include in your answer.

WHAT IS A LINE GRAPH?

A line graph shows how something changes over time, plotted as a continuous line.



It's the **most common chart type** in IELTS Writing Task 1.

TYPES OF LINE GRAPHS

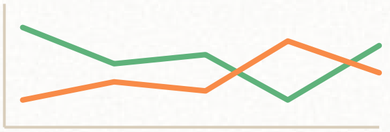
Single or multiple, read them differently.



Single line

Tracks one category over time, no comparison needed. Focus on the **shape and stages** of the trend.

"rose steadily, then plateaued, before climbing sharply"



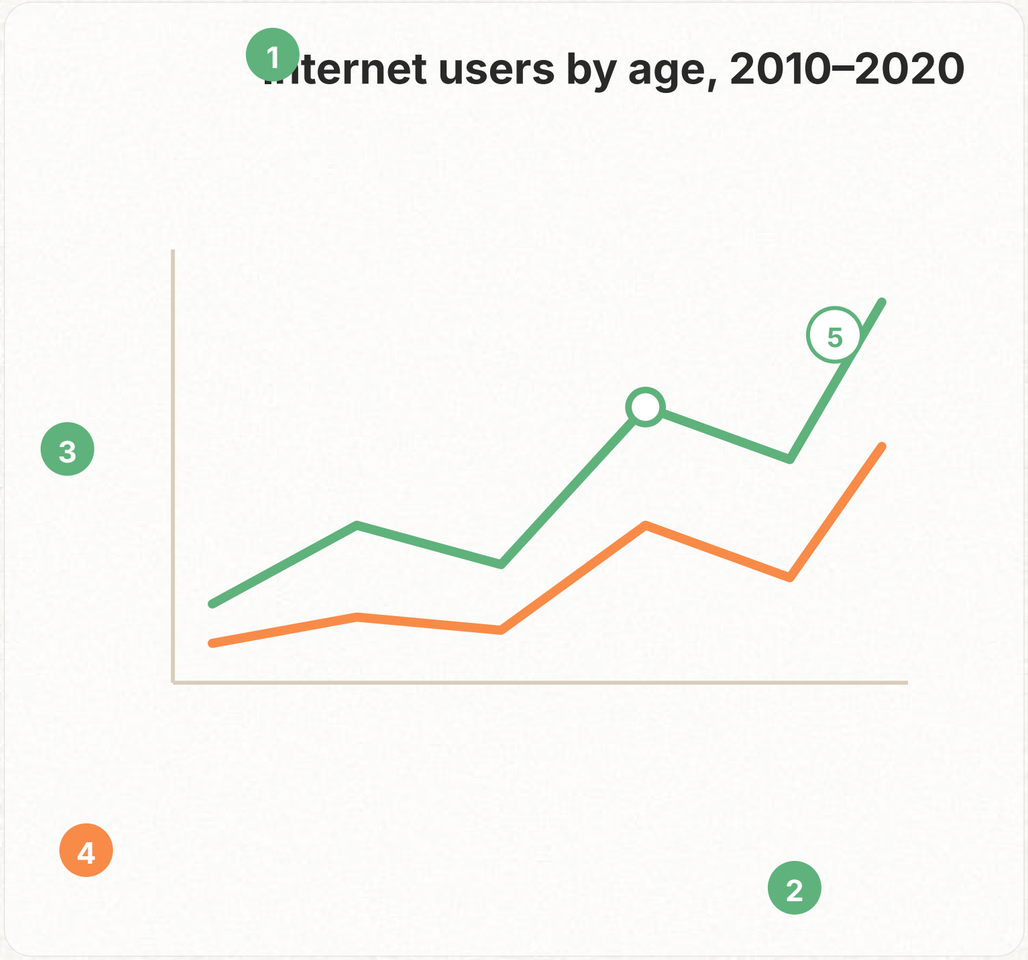
Multiple lines

Several trends to compare. Focus on **similarities, differences,** and the **crossover points** between lines.

"tea sales overtook coffee sales in 2015"

PARTS OF A LINE GRAPH

Know every part before you write.



examiner mode

1 **Title**, what's being measured.

2 **X-axis**, the time period.

3 **Y-axis**, the quantity measured, plus units (%, kg, millions).

4 **Legend**, which line is which.

5 **Data point**, the exact value at a given time.

reminder Always include **units** when describing values.

WHAT TASK 1 ASKS YOU TO DO

The instruction always asks three things:

follow the 3 steps →

01 Select

Choose the **most important** features. Don't describe everything.

02 Describe

Report the data **accurately**, with the right units.

03 Compare

Show how the lines **relate** to each other.

common mistake, repeating numbers

WEAK	STRONGER
The number went up a lot.	The number **increased sharply**.
Lots of people used it.	A **large proportion** used it.

KEY FEATURES TO NOTICE

Before you write, look for these five things.

01 Overall trend

Is it going up, down, or staying stable?

02 Start and end points

Where each line begins and finishes.

03 Significant changes

Sharp rises or sudden falls.

04 Peaks and troughs

The highest and lowest points.

05 Comparisons

Which line is highest, or whether lines cross.

ACTIVITY your turn!

Match each term to its definition.

Drag each term on the left to the meaning it belongs with on the right.

Title	What's being measured, the heading of the graph.
X-axis	The time period running along the bottom.
Y-axis	The quantity measured, running up the side.
Legend	The key showing which line is which.
Data points	The exact values plotted on each line.
Units	How values are counted, %, kg, millions.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What to carry into your writing.

- A line graph shows **change over time**, check the title, axes, and units first.
- Graphs can be **single or multiple**, read each kind differently.
- Task 1 asks you to **select, describe, and compare**, not describe everything.
- Look for the **overall trend, start/end points, peaks, troughs,** and comparisons.

next up →
Vocabulary for Trends